Children of a Lesser God

By Mark Medoff

NOTE: This selection should be both signed using ASL and spoken. For an example of the spoken word of the deaf, check out the video at this link:
http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uKKpjvPd6Xo

The following ALS speech, translated into standard English would have SARAH speaking . . . "I have nothing; no hearing, no speech, no intelligence, no language. I have only you. I don't need you. I have me alone. I don't want anything. I don't need what you want to give me. My language is just as good as yours"

NOTE 2: The remainder of the selection is written in standard English, but would need to be translated into ASL for the performance enhancement.

SARAH: *(Signing)* Me have nothing. Me defy. Speech inept. Intelligence – tiny blockhead. English – blow away. Left one you *(point to audience)* Depend – no. Think myself enough. What do I want? Nothing. I don't need what you want to give me. I have a language that's just as good as yours!

INTRODUCTION

"The Sounds of Silence." By Simon and Garfunkel relates the beauty of silence. But have we ever really taken it seriously - the sounds of silence? (mouth the following line with no sound) ***Can you even imagine what it is like to live in a world of total silence?*** *Did you get that? I just said: Can you even imagine what it is like to live in a world of total silence. You may have thought I had forgotten my lines, or maybe you were trying to read my lips. Welcome to the world of Sarah Norman, now in her mid-twenties who has been deaf from birth.*

Sarah's mother -- ashamed of her deafness -- pushed her aside and ignored her. Until she was 12, doctors and her own parents believed Sarah to be mentally handicapped. At a loss for how to cope with their broken child, her father left the family and Sarah's mother placed Sarah in a state-run institution for the deaf. But Sarah is far from mentally handicapped – she is brilliant and if you will come with me into Sarah's silent world, she will tell you . . . no . . . show you how it feels.

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SARAH: I have more than enough communication skills. You don't. They never did. They? Who's they? - Hearing boys. They could never be bothered learning my language. No - that was too difficult. I was always expected to learn to speak. The boys who did try to communicate with me got about as far as: How are you, I am fine. *(Pause)* At first I let them have me because they would. Sex was something I could do as well as hearing girls. Better! It got to be that when I went home, the boys would be lined up on a waiting list my sister kept for me. Most of them didn't even take me for a Coke first. No introductions. No conversations. We just went straight to a dark place. But I liked that communication. I loved it. It made me feel a lot better than this kind of talk you make. *(Pause)* I never hurt from other people. What if [I] admitted that I do hurt? I would shrivel up and blow away.

[You see] I live in a place you can't enter. It's out of your reach. Deafness isn't the opposite of hearing, as you think. It's a silence full of sound. The sound of spring breaking up through the death of winter. My secret. No hearing person has ever gotten in here to find out . . . No person, period.

[You know what I want?] I want to teach in a deaf school . . . . a house . . . a car. Plant a garden and . . . So much! A microwave oven! And children! Deaf children. My father left us because I'm deaf. [I want to go] on with my schooling and [get] a teaching certificate. *(with emphasis)* I know it's possible. [But] I feel split down the middle, caught between two worlds - deaf world here, *(motion to yourself)*, hearing world there *(motion to the audience)*. I hope I'm strong enough to juggle both. I'm too old to learn to speak and lip read well.

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("hears" music and responds by swaying her body, snapping her fingers) Listen to your music. I can enjoy your music. Really! The vibrations don't have a sound but they do have a feel. Fast. Slow. Very intense. Not so intense. And when I see people dancing, I feel still more. I can feel it . . . . Don't be sorry. I could never know what music sounds like. But I can understand what it means to you. And that makes me very happy. Ssshh. *(responds negatively as the "music" shifts to organ music)* I don't like this kind of music . . . organ music *(makes a face).* [You want to know why?]

When we were kids in school here, on Sunday they made us go to church. They played an organ fiercely. [My friend] cried because he could hear just enough for it to hurt his ears. The kids with hearing aids were forbidden to turn them off. We were told it was the voice of God and should hurt. They said we should love God for being so fierce and demanding. When [my friend] was nine and I was eleven, we started hiding in the trees behind the duck pond on Sunday. We pretended we were soldiers and threw dirt clods at the church and made sounds like hand grenades. *(Laugh and pretend to make grenade explosions with your hands in the air).*

(Long pause) I haven't left the deaf world. I haven't done anything yet. I don't know which role I'm supposed to play. [Some people] treat me like an idiot. Let me be a person! *(emphatic, yet pleading).* You want me to be a deaf person so you can change me into a hearing person. [Or you] want me to hate being deaf so all the hearing people will feel sorry for me. And I just want to be me! Don't pity me!

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For all my life I have been the creation of other people. The first thing I was ever able to understand was that everyone was supposed to hear but I couldn't and that was bad. Then they told me everyone was supposed to be smart but I was dumb. Then they said, oh no, I wasn't permanently dumb, only temporarily, but to be smart I had to become an imitation of the people who had from birth everything a person has to have to be good: ears that hear, mouth that speaks, eyes that read, brain that understands. Well, my brain understands a lot, and my eyes are my ears; and my hands are my voice; and my language, my speech, my ability to communicate is as great as yours. Greater, maybe, because I can communicate to you in one image an idea more complex than you can speak to each other in fifty words. For example, the sign "to connect," is a simple sign--but it means so much more when it is moved between us like this. Now it means to be joined in a shared relationship, to be individual yet as one. A whole concept just like that. Well, I want to be joined to other people, but for all my life people have spoken for me. She says; she means; she wants. As if there were no I. As if there were no one in here *(motion to chest or head)* who could understand. Until you let me be an individual, an *I*, just as you are, you will never truly be able to come inside my silence and know me. And until you can do that, I will never let myself know you. Until that time, we cannot be joined. We cannot share a relationship. *(Long pause).*

Me have nothing. Me deafy. Speech inept. Intelligence --tiny blockhead. English -- blow away. Left one you. Depend -- no. Think myself enough. Join. Unjoined.

You didn't hear a word I said. *(at first sadly, then with anger)* You want me to be like you. How do you like my voice? Am I beautiful? Am I what you want me to

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be? What about me? What I want? What I want? *(painfully and heartfelt).* To say I hurt and know I won't shrivel up and blow away . . . . to meet in another place; not in silence or in sound, but somewhere else.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mark Medoff
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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

NOTE: A good on-line resource for ASL is http://www.aslpro.com/cgi-bin/aslpro/aslpro.cgi A completely free online dictionary of over 7200 ASL Signs

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